

# Chicago Tribune



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## CHICAGO CITY COUNCIL

# Aides' pension costs create rift

### CULTURAL AFFAIRS PICK ADVANCES:

Aldermen advanced Mayor Brandon Johnson's pick, Kenya Merritt, to lead Chicago's cultural efforts Thursday over objections tied to a whistleblower lawsuit against her. Merritt has served as interim chief for the past six months. **Chicagoland, Page A3**

Progressive allies split with mayor over decision to pull staffers' payments from ward accounts

By Alice Yin  
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

City Council progressives are among those expressing fresh gripes over Mayor Brandon Johnson's move to make them cover pension costs for their part-time

aides, the latest City Hall rift as fiscal woes and political divisions from the fight over this year's budget continue to fester.

North Side Ald. Maria Hadden, 49th, on Wednesday wrote an email to her colleagues contending the mayor's office wants contribu-

tions to certain aldermanic staffers' pensions to come out of their ward expense accounts, according to a copy of the correspondence obtained by the Tribune. She added that she's met with the mayor and his budget director, Annette Guzmán, "to express my concerns."

"I believe that this is a cost-shifting decision that they do not have the authority to make without Council approval," Hadden, 49th,

wrote. "I am also prepared to take legislative action to prevent an action that would have a negative impact on constituent services for the majority of Council. ... I hope to have your support in objecting to this action."

Hadden's alarm stemmed from an aldermanic briefing from the Office of Budget Management and

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ANGELINA KATSANIS/AP

## CHICAGO PUBLIC SCHOOLS

# Decision on May 1 closure up in air

'Civic Day of Action' ruling faces pressure from union, City Hall

By Kate Armanini  
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Chicago Public Schools CEO Macqueline King rejected a request from the teachers union to cancel classes on May 1, but, facing pressure from City Hall and its allies in the district, said the board could ultimately overrule her decision.

In a statement late Thursday, she reiterated her opposition to the Chicago Teachers Union's "Civic Day of Action," but noted the board can take formal vote on the issue. She previously argued that canceling classes would significantly disrupt the district.

"My recommendation to the Chicago Board of Education for weeks and again during this week's Agenda Review Committee meeting, has been to maintain May 1 as an instructional day for students," King said. "As a career educator, I believe every minute in the classroom is vital for our students."

King urged the board to call a special meeting in order to make a decision "as soon as possible."

In an internal memo written Tuesday and obtained by the Tribune, King detailed her rationale to the board — and disputed CTU's claim that her decision would violate its contract with the district.

But during a closed-door meeting Wednesday, she faced fierce opposition from board members aligned with CTU and appointed by Mayor Brandon Johnson, who make

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# Setting an early agenda

Gov. JB Pritzker waits to take the stage to join the Rev. Al Sharpton at the National Action Network Convention in New York on Thursday. Pritzker was among Democratic Party politicians courting Black activists in New York as the party's unofficial 2028 presidential nomination contest takes shape at an annual conference led by Sharpton. Pritzker used his stage to tell attendees that "all of us need to be civil rights advocates" and protect voting rights, saying he thinks President Donald Trump plans to call out federal immigration agents to polling places for the November midterms. **Coverage in Chicagoland, Page A4**

# Madigan attorney makes case for appeal

By Jason Meisner  
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A lawyer for imprisoned House Speaker Michael Madigan told a federal appeals court on Thursday his conviction on an array of corruption counts should be overturned because there was no evidence that he agreed to enter into a bribery conspiracy with ComEd or took any specific official action on the utility's behalf.

In the long-awaited arguments before the 7th Circuit U.S. Court of Appeals, attorney Amy Saharia also argued that the district judge erred in several instructions given to the jury, and noted the alleged benefits Madigan received were "far outside" the typical bribery case.

The Democratic speaker took no cash from ComEd, Saharia said. He wasn't given any Rolex watches, or "trips to Vegas."

"The alleged benefit was that political allies were hired by ComEd," she said.

Assistant U.S. Attorney Julia Schwartz, however, told

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Technicians inspect the Artemis II heat shield in Florida in 2020. ISAAC WATSON/NASA

# Defect poses risk for Artemis

NASA confident in safe return of astronauts, despite known shortcomings of heat shield

By Kenneth Chang  
THE NEW YORK TIMES

The Artemis II heat shield, NASA agrees, is flawed.

The heat shield is the critical layer at the bottom of a spacecraft that protects it — and the astronauts inside — from searing temperatures upon reentering the Earth's atmosphere. If the shield fails, the underlying metallic structure could melt, rupture and disintegrate.

And there is no backup, and no way for the astronauts to escape.

But NASA officials are confident that despite the known shortcomings of the heat shield, the four Artemis II astronauts will remain alive and comfortable as they arrive at Earth on Friday at a speed of nearly 24,000 mph, concluding a 10-day trip to the moon and back.

Extensive analysis and testing of the heat shield material "got us comfortable that we can under-

take this mission with lots of margin to spare," NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman said in an interview in January.

However, Charlie Camarda, a former NASA astronaut and an expert on heat shields, says NASA should never have launched Artemis II. The agency does not understand well enough the chances that the heat shield might fail, he says, and the mission, a success so far, could end with the deaths of the astronauts.

His hunch is that there is a

See **DEFECT** on Page A9

## INSIDE



BUTCH DILL/AP

## The right fit?

With four picks in the top 89 selections, the Chicago Bears' challenge in the NFL draft can be viewed as a jigsaw puzzle for general manager Ryan Poles. **Sports**

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